TOPIC 2: COPING

Topic OBJECTIVE: The learner will:

- Explore and understand effective communication and self-care tactics that can be used to deal with difficult situations

Topic OUTCOME: The learner will:

- Identify their personal stress triggers and practice the use of effective coping strategies to help manage stress on the job

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students will understand the meaning of stress triggers.
Time: 20 minutes

Explain to students that at work, as well as other areas of their life, they may encounter people and situations that are stressful to deal with, and may test their coping and communication skills. And, if this person/event causes difficulty often, they may be seen as a "trigger" or starting place that "turns on" feelings of stress, anger, or anxiety for the student.

If comfortable, have students share examples of their "triggers," (a certain class, driving in traffic, being told you made a mistake, etc.) and ask them to discuss the ways in which they have coped with these triggers in the past (the instructor can give examples such as: walk away from the situation, get help from another person, seeing things from the other's point of view, compromising, deep breaths to stay calm, agree to disagree, etc.).

In addition to dealing directly with the person/situation, ask students to discuss ways in which they can "work off the stress" when they are away from the triggering person or event. Ask the group to explain how they feel when becoming stressed, in their body and mind, and how they might feel after using a healthy choice to cope.

Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Objective: Students will name specific ways they have managed stress in the past along with identifying new strategies.
Time: 20 minutes
Materials: Handouts: **"Stress and You"** and **"Tips for Reducing Stress,"** pens/pencils

After reading the handout, ask students to fill out the **"Stress and You"** worksheet and ask those who are comfortable to share some of their responses. Emphasize that there are verbal and non-verbal ways to respond to people, that can send powerful messages.

Hand out **"Tips for Reducing Stress,"** and ask students to circle the ideas that work for them or the ideas they would like to try. In addition, see how many other ideas class members can generate about safe/healthy ways to relieve stress. Students may flip over their worksheet to write down any other ideas they have or have heard from others that appeal to them.

Role-Play

Objective: Students will practice applying various communication strategies to realistic life situations.
Time: 20 minutes
Materials: Handout: **"Role-Plays for Coping at Work,"** pens/pencils

If students are comfortable, ask students to pair together and choose three role-plays from the sheet **"Role-Plays for Coping at Work,"** and circle them. Next, have them (by themselves) choose what they may do/say for each scenario, choosing a coping strategy from the list on **"Stress and You,"** or others they may have. Ask students to then share and compare ideas with their partners. If pair work is not a good option, the instructor can lead the activity as a group, or modify it by having students complete the activity independently, writing their strategies down rather than sharing aloud. The activity can be extended by having students imagine the dialogue from the "other side" (the person with whom the subject in the role-plays is having a problem with) and what they might say in response.

Stress and You

Directions: *Think about your past stressful events. List three stressful events for each category. Then answer the discussion questions.*

FAMILY

_____

_____

_____

WORK/SCHOOL

_____

_____

_____

FRIENDS/RELATIONSHIPS

_____

_____

_____

What physical and emotional signs of stress did you have?

_____

Time to Cope:

What have you tried in the past to cope with this person/situation?

_____

Did it work? Why or why not?

_____

Possible New Coping Strategies:

- ☐ Choose my Battles
- ☐ Limit Contact
- ☐ Resist instigating ("stirring up trouble")
- ☐ Detach with kindness
- ☐ No put-downs
- ☐ Accept reality (some things are hard to change)
- ☐ See things from "the other's side"
- ☐ Ask a neutral person to mediate (help you resolve/compromise)
- ☐ Take Care of Myself
- ☐ Avoid Holding a Grudge
- ☐ Be clear and fair in your position
- ☐ Take a breather/break from it
- ☐ Use "I" statements instead of accusations
- ☐ Have patience
- ☐ Give the other person choices/a "way out"

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

Tips for Reducing Stress

In today's world most people can't avoid stress. They can learn to behave in ways that lessen the effects of stress. The following factors can help keep stress at a minimum.

Read the list. Put an **X** beside the statements that apply to you.

___ 1. Eat at least one hot, balanced meal a day.

___ 2. Get 7 to 8 hours of sleep at least 4 nights a week.

___ 3. Give and receive affection regularly.

___ 4. Have at least one relative within 50 miles that I can rely on.

___ 5. Exercise to the point of perspiration at least twice a week.

___ 6. Limit myself to less than half a pack of cigarettes a day.

___ 7. Take fewer than five alcoholic drinks a week.

___ 8. Am the correct weight for my height.

___ 9. Have an income that meets my basic expenses.

___ 10. Get strength from my spiritual beliefs.

___ 11. Have a network of friends.

___ 12. Have more than one friend to confide in.

___ 13. Am in good health.

___ 14. Regularly attend club or social activities.

___ 15. Am able to speak openly about my feelings.

___ 16. Regularly talk about problems at home with the people I live with.

___ 17. Do something for fun at least once a week.

___ 18. Am able to manage my time effectively.

___ 19. Drink fewer than three cups of coffee or high caffeine drinks a day.

___ 20. Take some quiet time for myself during the day.

___ 21. Am a positive thinker.

___ 22. Am aware that support groups can help people work through a common problem.

___ 23. Am assertive and able to stand up for myself.

___ 24. Am aware that keeping a journal of stressful events can help me become aware of how I handle stress.

___ 25. Am aware that picturing myself in a wonderful setting can be a temporary way to relieve stress.

Healthy/Safe Activities to Reduce Stress:

walking

running

playing with clay and play-doh

listening to music

playing music

playing basketball

reading a book

dancing

playing a computer game

riding a bike

calling a friend

writing a letter

playing football

attending a free concert

taking a nature hike

learning a new hobby

taking a hot shower or bath

lighting a candle

taking deep breaths

visualization

drawing or painting

learning a new sport

relaxation CDs

taking in a local play or some local sports

cooking or baking something

WHICH ONES DO YOU DO?

WHICH ONES WOULD YOU LIKE TO TRY?

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

Role-Plays for Coping at Work

- You are in the break room, and a co-worker makes a racist slur (insult) about another co-worker. What could you do?
- Someone at work vandalized some of your personal property. You think you know who did it. How do you approach that person/the situation?
- You and a co-worker are in charge of "cashing out" for the night. Your co-worker often makes mistakes while tallying the money, and you both have gotten blamed in the past. What could you say?
- You usually pick up your co-worker and ride to work together. However, he's been late the last three days, and you've had to wait for him to get ready, thus getting to work late. He/s late again today, what do you do?
- You worked very hard to finish a task at work. However, when your supervisor comes by, your co-worker (who did next to nothing) accepts all the praise and credit for herself. What do you say to her? To your supervisor?
- Your supervisor constantly asks for your input on small/everyday decisions, but then shoots your suggestions down, and does the opposite. What could you do?
- Your co-worker loves to talk and has great stories. You really like this person, and they make you laugh every day. However, you notice neither of you getting enough work done when you're talking. What steps could you take?
- You are unsure of how to do a task at work. You ask a co-worker for help. They help you, but are being rude and sarcastic doing it. They hint that they think you are stupid. What do you do?